How does the implementation of solar systems impact the development of Central Africa?

Assumptions

When I began this project, I expected to determine that the implementation of solar systems had a positive effect on local socioeconomic states in Central Africa. However, I soon found that its effect on socioeconomic states was more complex and confounded than a simple scalar boost.

Definitions

Photovoltaics: Materials that convert solar energy into electrical energy
Central Africa: A subregion of the African continent centered primarily around the Congo Basin
Development: Measured as the score on the inequality-adjusted human development index
Solar Resource: the total amount of electromagnetic radiation emitted by the sun that reaches a specific geographic area on Earth

Perspectives

Falchetta focuses on the feasibility and economic potential of solar-based irrigation systems in Sub-Saharan Africa. It found that "irrigation could support smallholder farmers with stabilizing crop yields, increasing incomes, and achieving food security" while "a key barrier to irrigation uptake is inadequate solar electricity . . . [we devise a] modeling framework to show that over one third of unmet crop water requirements . . . could be supplied with standalone solar photovoltaic (PV) irrigation systems that can be paid back by farmers within 20 years" (Falchetta et al.).

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